March last year, 65-year-old Kacchalapu Satyam's life unravelled soon after he took up a contract to produce maize seeds. His crop, sown over 10 acres in Chirutapalli village of Telangana's Mulugu district, failed. His wife, Rajamma, suffered paralysis, reportedly due to food poisoning from discarded maize tassels. His 40-year-old son, Chandra Rao, weighed down by debt, died by suicide. They were not alone. Across 1,500 acres in Telangana, 671 small tribal farmers reported similar crop failures after planting maize seeds that promised yields of four tonnes per acre but delivered barely one.

If the Union government has its way, a new law—expected to be tabled in Parliament in the monsoon session—will prevent precisely such episodes by tightening oversight of seed quality and accountability. In a country where over 45 per cent of the workforce depends on agriculture, the rules governing seeds extend well beyond the farm—carrying implications for food security, biodiversity and even public health. It is against this backdrop that the Draft Seeds Bill, 2025, seeks to replace the Seeds Act, 1966, and the Seeds (Control) Order, 1983. When these laws were framed, hybrid seeds, genetically modified varieties and seed royalties were non-existent, and the public sector dominated supply. Today, private firms account for nearly 75 per cent of seed sales, and the absence of a comprehensive registration process has created regulatory gaps.

PUSH FOR QUALITY

The new bill has been more than two decades in the making—first introduced in 2004 and revised in 2010 and 2019 before its current iteration. Its stated objective is to regulate seed quality, ensure farmers' access to reliable inputs and protect them from losses, while also liberalising imports to promote innovation and widen access to global varieties. To "align with current requirements", it proposes a more comprehensive regulatory architecture across the value chain. At a mid-January press conference, Union agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan further outlined the government's position: "Every farmer should get quality seeds. Good companies will be encouraged, and those who do wrong will face strict action. That is the essence of this law."

At its core is a shift towards mandatory, testing-based registration of all seed varieties, whether developed by public or private entities, and quality certification by the government or accredited organisations. This marks a departure from the current system, where many seeds are sold as "truthfully labelled", i.e. effectively certified by companies themselves. The bill extends accountability across the supply chain—producers, processors, dealers, distributors and nurseries must all be registered. It also introduces traceability norms, including QR codes on seed packets, to bring greater transparency and enable farmers to verify certification details and quality standards before purchase.

Penalties are significantly tightened. At present, fines are modest—Rs 500 for a first offence and Rs 1,000 or six months' imprisonment for repeat violations. The draft proposes graded penalties, with fines rising to as much as Rs 30 lakh, along with up to three-year jail, for "major" repeat offences such as the sale of spurious or non-registered seeds.

Yet, even as the draft seeks to modernise regulation, its release in November 2025 triggered debate—from its apparent tilt towards industry at the expense of farmers to the curtailment of the role of state governments in regulating seed registration and pricing.

SEED OF DOUBT

The organised segment of India's seed market is projected to reach Rs 35,500 crore in the 2026–27 crop year, followed by a compound annual growth rate of 4–5 per cent over the next five years, according to the analytics firm Crisil Intelligence. Yet about 55 per cent of the market remains unorganised, largely driven by farm-saved seeds—underscoring the headroom for formalisation.

It is this shift that worries some stakeholders. G.V. Ramanjaneyulu, executive director of the Centre for Sustainable Agriculture, Hyderabad, says that the draft reads more like a trade law geared towards "creating opportunities for industry and promoting ease of doing business". Instead, he suggests, "a seeds law should be a rights-based framework that protects farmers' rights and safeguards biodiversity".

Perhaps the most contested aspect is how the bill treats farmers' rights. While it recognises their right to grow, sow, save, use, exchange, share and sell seeds, this is restricted to varieties registered under the act. For Kavitha Kuruganti, co-convenor of the Alliance for Sustainable & Holistic Agriculture (ASHA-Kisan Swaraj), this narrows what has historically been a broad, community-driven practice. "The draft bill could have simply left the right as a right over any seed," she says. Kuruganti also flags the bill's use of the term "farmer" in the



"EVERY FARMER SHOULD GET QUALITY SEEDS. THEY WILL NOW KNOW THE COMPLETE STORY OF EVERY SEED. INFERIOR SEEDS WILL NOT COME INTO THE SYSTEM; EVEN IF THEY DO, THEY WILL BE CAUGHT"

SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN, *Union Minister for Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare*